

Part V — The Hinge

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The confession beat closes on the Father — *You walked into that room by yourself* — and the room's eyes move to the one Character who has refused to speak. The Son deflects, is dragged in, and gives the family its coldest account of itself: strangers arriving with obligations, a mother he never knew, a role he never agreed to play. The Step-Daughter's long attack on the Son needs shape, not volume — attack, then wound, then disgust, then a turn of tenderness toward the Mother; never all screamed.

It ends with the Father offering the Manager the drama's hook — the little girl vanishes first, then the boy, then she runs — and the Manager, despite himself, beginning to see a play.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

Stillness as refusal — his body simply won't enter the scene, the only sovereignty left to a son who has been handed a role he never agreed to play.

THE SON [*the Father, cornered, has turned to his son — and the room's eyes follow. The Son keeps his hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Don't look at me. I don't come into this.

Not a question but a demand: the Father needs the Son onstage to complete his tableau and cannot accept that a character might simply walk off the stage.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

Being "mixed up" with them feels contaminating; the Son is fighting to keep the family story from adhering to him like a stain he can never wash off.

THE SON. I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

Class irony turned to weapon: she calls herself vulgar to expose his pretension, then conscripts the Manager as witness to a shaming the Son cannot sidestep.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

One syllable of disbelief that is not innocence — it's an instinct to contest the record before it hardens into fact against him.

THE SON [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

An indictment reframed as domestic history: "mistress of the house" reclaims a dignity the Son's cold contempt had already stripped from her family.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. You — you! I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

Switching from accused to narrator, he repaints the Step-Daughter as threatening and mercenary — a defence against the charge of cruelty that makes him sound crueller.

THE SON. It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. One day, gentlemen, a young woman of impudent bearing arrives at my home, asking for my father. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there — and asks him for money, in a way that lets one suppose he *must* give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

Calm, almost proud admission; acknowledging the debt to the Mother positions him as honourable and quietly blunts the Son's implicit charge of exploitation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

"Unrealised" becomes both self-diagnosis and escape hatch: name yourself incomplete and no complete action — no complete guilt — can ever be pinned to you.

THE SON. How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her *[Indicating Step-Daughter.]* that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

He senses the philosophical leverage in the Son's self-erasure and starts to turn it back on him — but the trap closes before he can finish the sentence.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

His counter-question is the truest thing anyone has said about this family — and then, the one time, the cold cracks: they need him guilty precisely because he did nothing, the scapegoat of inaction.

THE SON. How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me? *[the one time the cold cracks]* You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing.

The Mother's tears are pointed at the Manager like an exhibit; genuine pain is being stage-managed in front of a stage manager, and nobody blinks.

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... *[Pointing out the Mother to the Manager.]* See, she's crying!

Three words of flat contempt; by refusing the Mother's grief as weakness, she shows how completely she has shut herself to anything that resembles softness.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[without looking at the Mother].* Like a fool.

The Boy's silence becomes ammunition: the Father turns a mute child's suffering into dramatic argument, weaponising his pain to pressure the Son.

THE FATHER *[indicating Step-Daughter].* She can't stand him, you know. *[Then referring again to the Son.]* He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. *[In confidence.]* The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

Brutal pragmatism laid bare — inconvenient bodies, especially children's, are simply cut; the stage keeps only what it can use.

THE MANAGER. Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

He stops explaining and lets the ending haunt — the children gone, a family left in one house unable to belong to one another, the wound the whole play will circle.

THE FATHER. The little girl vanishes first. Then the boy. Then she runs. And what remains? Three people in the same house, unable to belong to one another. A family, perhaps — but without faith, without warmth, without any place where happiness could take root.